

# Co-Founder Questionnaire

## Answers

2026-07-04

Answers to [First Round's \\*50 Questions for Co-Founders\\*](#).

# How You Operate

## **1. What are your strengths and superpowers (beyond functional expertise)?**

Creativity and making people feel comfortable around me.

## **2. What are your weaknesses? How do you try to compensate for them?**

People pleasing - can hinder open communication and sales. I compensate by prioritising direct communication and reframing sales as a thrilling challenge.

## **3. What words would your co-workers use to describe you? What would they want me to know about what it's like to work with you?**

Fun, personable, laughs to cope with stress. Obsessed with shipping right now.

## **4. How do you deal with conflict? Describe a time you dealt with it well - and a time you didn't.**

—

## **5. What's the worst interpersonal conflict you've dealt with? How did you handle it?**

I used to be conflict-avoidant. Now I raise issues early. Recently, planning a startup with a friend, we hit misalignment on equity - I sat down over coffee immediately and we pivoted to a better-fit project.

If conflict gives me anxiety, it's time to address it, with openness, honesty and kindness.

## **6. How do you cope with stress? Depression? Are there any red flags I can help watch out for?**

I eat more when stressed. Otherwise I stay level-headed. I've encountered some very stressful situations in life and realised I'm pretty good with it.

**7. How do you arrive at your convictions? What are some key mental models you use to be creative, solve problems, or make decisions?**

The world model loop: I hold a theory of how the world works. I receive sensory input, act according to my world model, and observe what happens, and compare the result to what I expected. The gap updates the model. Over time, perception gets sharper - same structure as the scientific method. I think this holds on an organisation scale too - you have a business thesis, you act, you observe, you update the thesis.

Regarding creativity, problem-solving, and decisions. Favor whatever strengthens this loop.

On a personal level, I'm also living by three maxims, which I think relate to the above:

1. Follow the dopamine - if something feels good, do more of it (unless it's known to be addictive: drugs, porn, etc. These must be moderated).
2. Stir the pot - given two choices that seem to have, roughly equal cost and benefit - choose the one most likely to bring you into unfamiliar territory.
3. Be open, honest, and kind - if you've got something on your mind, tell people, as long as you do it with kindness.

**8. Describe your work style. What techniques do you use for personal productivity?**

Biased toward getting user feedback on anything, as fast as possible. Personal techniques - I prefer to knock out hard mundane tasks first thing (meditation, exercise, admin) while caffeine is ok as early-day fuel.

**9. How many hours/week are you willing to work? For how long? What sounds good? What sounds like hell? Do you have different expectations for different phases of the company's lifespan?**

As much as possible without sacrificing sleep and daily time for core friends/family/exercise. Happy to be a bit of a hermit in early stages. What sounds like hell - doing this alone. Very important to me to be physically colocated.

Duration of this intensity depends on exit friendliness of the idea. If less exit friendly, best to work out a more sustainable worklife balance after it gets off the ground.

# Roles

**10. What would you want your role to be before we reach product/market fit? What would you want your role to be after we reach product/market fit?**

CEO or co-CEO. As co-CEOs we'd need to be aligned on most things, and take turns on. However, depends on the idea - if the other cofounder is the domain expert, CEO may not make sense for me. In any case, the most important thing is to prioritise user feedback and take a 'scientific method' type approach to decision making.

**11. How do you see your role changing as the company starts to scale?**

Firstly, regarding scale, I'd prefer to keep the company as small as possible (minimise communication overhead and maximise speed). Past ~30 people (can't all work in the same room), I'd move to a role focused on organisational design and product strategy.

**12. If your role becomes unavailable entirely (e.g. the board hires a professional CEO or an experienced executive), what would you want your new role to be?**

Product direction.

**13. Areas of Responsibility (AoR) Exercise**

- Sales: 5
- Marketing: 5
- Product / Strategy: 8
- Design: 7
- Engineering: 8
- Operations: 6
- Fundraising: 5
- Leadership: 8
- Company building: 6
- Recruiting: 6
- Legal: 3
- Specific skills (web dev, AI engineering): 7

# Corporate Structure and Funding

**14. Where should our startup be based? How do you feel about remote or distributed teams?**

Sydney. Heavily prefer in-person. I can host a workspace in the CBD of Sydney (between Wynyard and Town Hall). I would be open to working in Brisbane or Melbourne.

**15. Is there anything I should know that may materially affect your time or legal status as a founder?**

No.

**16. How should founder equity be set? What's your philosophy on the employee equity pool?**

Equal split by default. Open to discussion.

**17. What should our approach to employee compensation be, including cash and equity?**

Better to hire one "A-player" than 3 "B-players". Pay above market (cash + equity) to find and retain these people.

**18. How much money should we raise? ...where do you want this startup to go?**

Depends on exit strategy, which depends on the idea.

**19. What matters most in a funder? If you were doing reference checks on a VC or potential board member, what traits would you be looking for?**

—

**20. What does an ideal company exit look like to you?**

See Q9.

**21. How do you think about the timeframe and pace of success? Are you willing to take the longer path? How long is too long?**

See Q9.

**22. What number would you sell at? How would that change if you got extra liquidity from your existing positions?**

Depends on remaining upside vs. flattening growth and whether the valuation makes sense.

**23. What do we do if we find product/market fit, yet none of the founders are excited about that product?**

Sell at whatever valuation we can get. PMF is attractive, but we won't do good work without excitement.

**24. Can one co-founder fire another co-founder? Can someone else fire a founder?**

Work out agreements for this ahead of time.

## Personal Motivation

**25. Why do you want to start a company - in general, and in particular right now?**

I'm excited for the journey (new experiences, new learnings), the possible financial upside, and the opportunity to have a direct hand in changing people's lives for the better through a good product/service. Why now? Because I've got life experience but don't have kids yet! I feel the most able I've ever felt.

**26. What is success to you? What motivates you personally?**

In this arena, building a product/service so good it feels like a privilege to buy - not because it's good value but because there's nothing else like it. I think financial success is a natural byproduct.

**27. What impact do you want to have? ...Is control or success more important?**

Both getting rich and changing the world - they stem from the same action. Success > control, but depends on the idea. If users are vulnerable (e.g. we do something in aged care), control would be more important than success to make sure nothing bad happens to them.

**28. What makes you gritty?**

I've had a gritty life! A lot of personal tragedy.

**29. Who do you admire most in your organization/family/friends and why?**

Probably my father - a good person through and through, and always trying to improve the community by starting community organisations. And my grandfather - an entrepreneur who came to Australia at 14 and built a successful business.

**30. What are you most proud of in your work career or life to date?**

Whatever I've decided to do, I've put my mind to it and done it. Proud to made a complete career switch to STEM, having been purely humanities-focused earlier in life. Proud of getting through a lot of personal tragedy - people say it's impressive that I'm functional.

**31. When have you taken a chance when others did not? Or when have you been willing to take an unpopular stance?**

Left my last engineering job - probably the first role I was really proud of (good position, good company) - because my mental health was bad. This ended up being the corect decision.

**32. What are some of the products and companies you love, and why?**

AirPods - use every day, never regretted it, they just work.

A hostel in Chiang Mai called The Yard - every part felt designed with care. Felt like a home, not just a hostel. Genuinely an incredible product, and I've been in many hostels... I can go into more detail on this one

Agentic AI (Various products) - not perfect, but being able to effect change by describing it in natural language feels like magic, esp when you connect it to external systems.

**33. Is it possible to build a wildly successful company without burning out or damaging other parts of your life (family, health, etc.)?**

Yes. You have to be careful and clear-headed - make sure everyone is working efficiently, not just grinding for the sake of it. Carve out time for family and health. Work and life can coexist.

## **Commitment & Finances**

**34. Will this company be your primary activity? Do you have any other time commitments?**

Yes - primary activity.

**35. What is your expected time commitment right now? How do you see that changing in the next 6 months? 2 years?**

Full time for forseeable future.

**36. What is your personal runway? Current burn rate? Would you invest your own money (ideally retaining higher equity in return)?**

I have a decent amount saved and a good support network. Could operate for a while with low salary.

**37. What is the minimum monthly salary you need to survive? To be comfortable? To feel like you've "made it?"**

Floor of "made it": ~\$AU120k/year, excellent work-life balance, meaningful work. Ceiling is very high. I'd prefer to aim for a very high ceiling.

**38. What should the policy of co-founders advising/consulting with other companies be?**

Advising a direct competitor - no. Otherwise, if there's a personal relationship or strategic alignment, a little is probably okay. Ideally you'd be focused on this company.

## Team Culture

**39. Complete the sentence: It would make you proud to hear people describe this company's culture as \_\_\_\_.**

Caring. If you can be successful and genuinely caring, that would be incredible.

**40. What's your philosophy on how to attract and retain great people? Tactically, how would we make this happen at our company?**

Personal referrals. Put real money on the table - pay a premium for great people, which fits with keeping headcount low. Interview process would simulate work they'd do on the job so we can get a good idea of their immediate impact.

**41. What processes or techniques would you use to get the most out of your team? For example, how would you help them become better managers or achieve their goals?**

—

**42. How much of your time do you hope to spend either working or socializing with coworkers?**

Set aside time for coworkers to socialise without it being work-focused - better bonds improve communication.



**43. How important is diversity & inclusion? Concretely, how would you put that into action?**

Given two engineers of similar ability, I'd pick whoever adds more diversity to the team - different perspectives are valuable. Could use a scoring mechanism weighing diversity contribution against likelihood of hiring them. Ability still matters, but diversity is a tiebreaker.

## Co-Founder Relationship

**44. Specifically, how are we going to prioritize and make time for our co-founder relationship as we get increasingly busy with company building?**

Check in regularly. Eat together - lunch in the office at minimum. Maybe rotate cooking lunch with different people. People who eat together stay together.

**45. How would we resolve personal conflict between ourselves? How about stalemates?**

Bring up personal conflict as soon as possible. For stalemates: alternate who gets the tiebreaker vote - on stalemate, it's someone's turn and we do their thing.

**46. In case this becomes part of our partnership's evolution, how would you go about handling a startup divorce?**

Agreement in place before we start - written down. So either person can invoke it without hard feelings; we both know what we've committed to do to break up cleanly.

**47. What happens in the scenario where we aren't growing? How would we diagnose the problem? How have each of our capabilities and approach contributed to growth failures in our pasts?**

Continually be honest: are things working or not? Use metrics (Startup School-style) as a starting point for those conversations - imperfect, but useful.

My past: Took ~7 years to internalise "make something people want." Spent too long making things before checking if I was making what people wanted. That contributed to failure to grow past side projects. Now I'm laser-focused on it - if you focus on what people want, you'll grow.

**48. In every partnership, there are times when a partner might breed resentment if certain dissatisfactions don't change over time. How would you deal with a situation like this?**

Voice dissatisfactions continuously. Everyone on the same page about what they're looking for. If we can't resolve it, that's grounds for a startup divorce - ideally we'd find a compromise first.

**49. How would you think about bringing on a third (or N+1) cofounder?**

The more the merrier, up to company size cap. Equity would depend on what they bring to the table.

**50. Wrap up question: ...how are we going to make each other successful?**

Make sure the other person is honest about making something people want - continuously finding out what people want, making that thing, and supporting each other to do it.